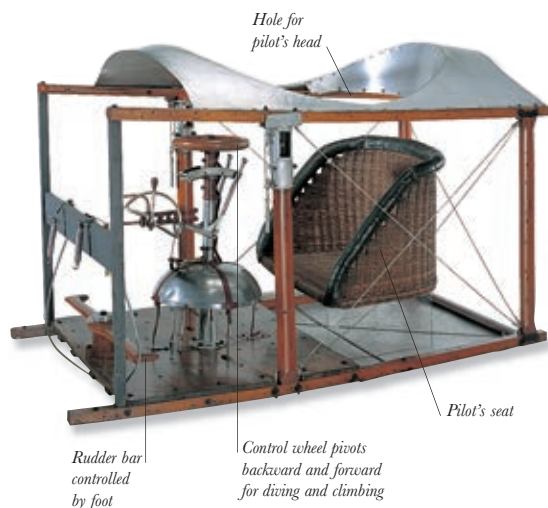


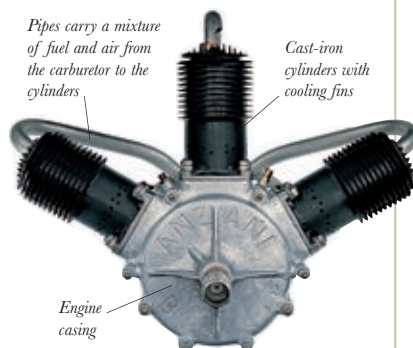
OPEN COCKPIT

Before the development of safety glass in the late 1920s, pilots sat in the open, exposed to howling winds, freezing cold, and damp. Blériot's cockpit had a rudder bar at the pilot's feet, while a control column (patented by Blériot) between the knees operated the wing warping and elevators.



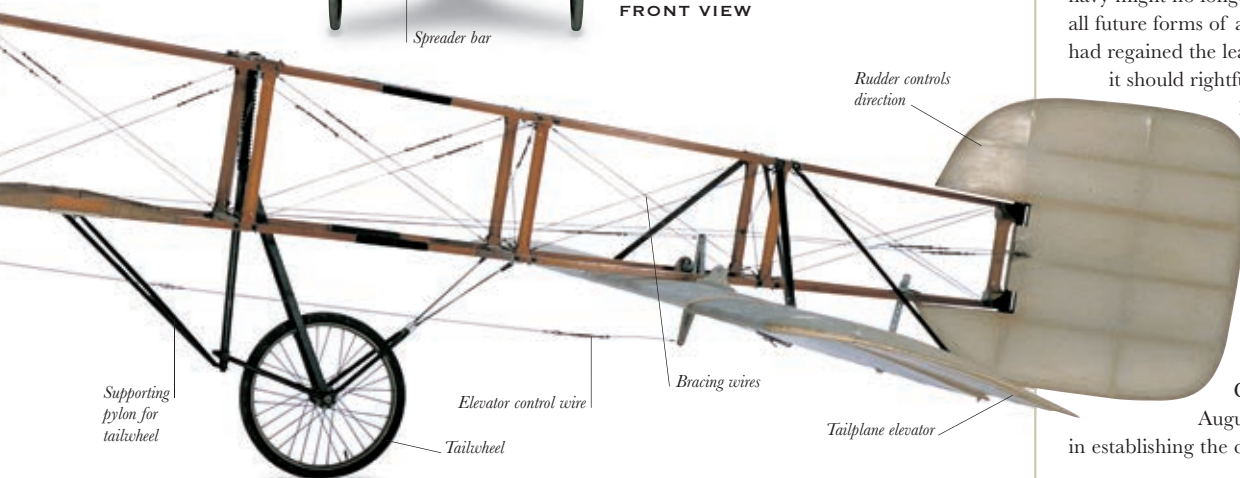
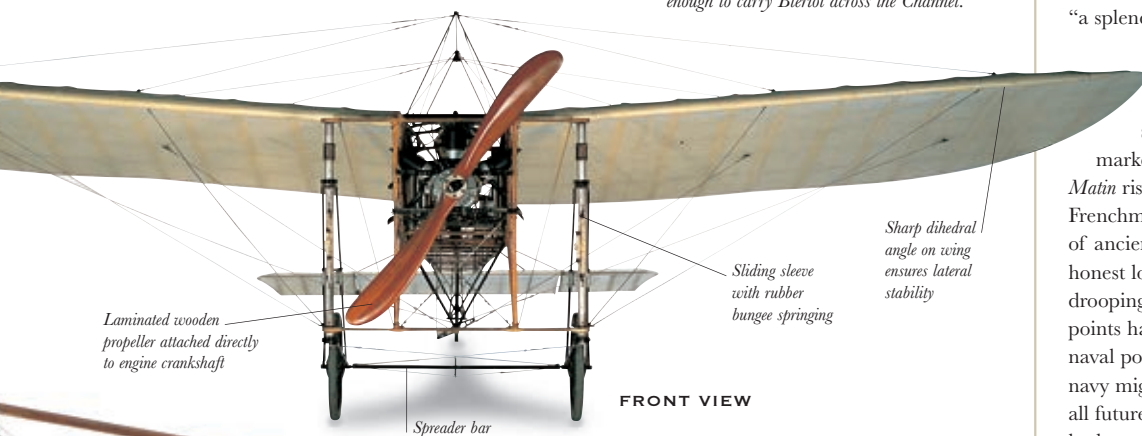
Specifications

ENGINE	25hp Anzani three-cylinder air-cooled semiradial
WINGSPAN	25ft 6in (7.8m)
LENGTH	26ft 3in (8m)
HEIGHT	8ft 10in (2.7m)
WEIGHT	661lb (300kg)
TOP SPEED	36mph (58kph)



MOTORCYCLE ENGINE

The Blériot XI's unusual three-cylinder engine was originally developed by Alessandro Anzani for racing motorcycles. It was barely powerful enough to carry Blériot across the Channel.



warship was alerted and the aviator impatiently awaited sunrise, when his epic journey began. "At half past four we could see all around. Daylight had come. My thoughts were only upon the flight and my determination to accomplish it this morning. Four thirty-five. *Tout est prêt!* In an instant I am in the air, my engine making 1,200 revolutions – almost its highest speed. As soon as I am over the cliff I reduce my speed. There is now no need to force my engine.

I begin my flight, steady and sure, toward the coast of England..." The rest is history.

Following his successful crossing, Blériot was quite unprepared for the sensation his flight would cause. After a celebratory lunch with his wife and friends, he returned across the Channel by boat, patently expecting to continue with his life. The newspapers had other ideas. Blériot was obliged to return immediately to England and attend a glittering dinner set up by the *Daily Mail* at the Savoy Hotel in London. He was then taken back to Paris in the grip of the newspaper *Le Matin*, which suspended his monoplane outside its Paris offices to be viewed by passers-by. In both capitals, Blériot was mobbed by delirious crowds.

In truth his flight had not been a striking technological achievement – British aviation historian Charles Gibbs-Smith described it as, "a splendid feat of daring, aided by good luck, performed in an unsuitable machine."

Much of the response to it was what would now be called "media hype." Not surprisingly, the *Daily Mail* felt the flight marked "the dawn of a new age for man." *Le Matin* risked ridicule by describing this bourgeois Frenchman as reminiscent of the "robust defenders of ancient Gaul," because of "his direct and honest look, and above all his long and powerful drooping whiskers." Yet symbolically, two crucial points had been made. Britain, the world's greatest naval power, had been forced to recognize that its navy might no longer be able to defend it against all future forms of attack from abroad. And France had regained the lead in world aviation that it felt it should rightfully possess, a lead it would hold for some years to come.

The Reims meeting

Although no other event of 1909 could match the Channel crossing for the scale of publicity it attracted, the air meeting officially known as the Grande Semaine d'Aviation de la Champagne, which followed in

August, was even more important in establishing the credibility of heavier-than-air